



STEPPE

Funding Strategy & Pipeline

Central Oregon funders

REDMOND • CENTRAL OREGON • EST. 2026

v3 • 2026-07-09

A member-governed Oregon public benefit nonprofit.

Internal note • 2026-07-09. Working draft, converted from Word to Markdown and rebranded to Steppe. Facts to rely on: the fiscal sponsor is **Ignite Empowerment Foundation**, a Central Oregon 501(c)(3) (EIN 99-3872440), with the sponsorship agreement pending signature. Director Brandon Weimer is the spouse of the foundation's founder, so Steppe and the foundation handle their arrangement as a disclosed related party (see docs/governance/). Dues are **\$4 a month**. The founding board is Chism, Cobb, and Weimer, with a fourth independent director planned. Before sending this to a funder, apply the open items in docs/funding/funder-pack-corrections-v1.md (grant-ask sizing, board-independence wording, and the 2026 pipeline dates).

STEPPE

Funding Strategy & Pipeline — v3

June 2026 • Companion to Business Plan v12 • Deadlines verified June 10, 2026 — reconfirm at each portal before submitting

Resiliency means no single funder — public or private — can bend this. Dues fund the core; everything else is additive, diversified, capped, and disclosed.

This document maps every viable funding source for Steppe, sequenced for speed and built for resiliency. Private funding leads; a separate government track follows, on Steppe's transparency terms. The Master Case for Support and the Grant Applications Pack are companions — the reusable narrative and the ready-to-send letters.

01 --- Act This Month: the Critical Path

THE Almost every institutional funder requires either a 501(c)(3) determination letter or a fiscal sponsor.

GATE Steppe's determination is months away — so a fiscal sponsorship agreement is the single unlock for 2026 money. Securing one is this month's most important funding task.

Verified Time-Sensitive Windows (as of June 10, 2026)

Opportunity	Deadline	Status & Move
OCF Fall Community Grants (up to \$40K; typical \$15-20K)	June 23, 2026, 5pm — new-applicant account form by June 18	Open now; accepts fiscal sponsorship (materials due with application) and requires Oregon DOJ registration. Honest call: feasible only if a sponsor signs within days. Register the MyOCF account by June 18 regardless — it costs nothing and unlocks the Spring 2027 cycle (apps Dec-mid-Jan, which prioritized small rural and culturally responsive organizations in 2026).
Roundhouse Foundation — Fall Open Call	Window open June–August 2026	Open now. Sisters-based, rural Central Oregon is the home turf, and they explicitly fund fiscally-sponsored projects. This is the flagship 2026 target. Decisions ≈ 8-12 weeks.
Roundhouse Foundation — Small Grants	Rolling LOIs through Nov 30	Open now. Entry-level grassroots grants; the fastest credible institutional dollars available. Submit the LOI (in the Grant Pack) as soon as sponsorship is signed.

Ford Family Foundation — Good Neighbor / Technical Assistance	Rolling, no deadline	Open, but call the program officer first — see the eligibility note in §02. TA grants (orgs under \$1M budget) can fund formation and fundraising capacity.
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Fiscal Sponsor --- Decision This Week

- **What it is** — an established 501(c)(3) receives restricted grants and donations on Steppe’s behalf for a 5-10% admin fee until the determination letter arrives. Roundhouse and OCF both accept sponsored applicants by policy.
- **First call: Connect Central Oregon** — a regional capacity-building nonprofit whose explicit role is incubating and partnering with Central Oregon organizations — either a direct sponsor or the best-positioned source of a referral to one. Other local candidates come through Compass’s and Herringbone’s board networks. Ask: “would you sponsor a six-to-twelve-month pass-through while our determination is pending, or point us to who would?”
- **National fallbacks** — established multi-project sponsors (e.g., Social Good Fund and similar 501(c)(3) sponsor organizations) sign quickly at standard fees if no local option lands within two weeks.
- **Exit built in** — the agreement should state that grants and donor relationships transfer to Steppe upon determination.

Also This Month (no sponsor needed)

- Oregon DOJ Charitable Activities registration — required before soliciting; file with formation paperwork
- MyOCF nonprofit account — by June 18
- Roundhouse introduction — email or call; they welcome pre-application contact, and Sisters is a short drive: go in person
- Founding Supporters campaign design — individual giving launches with the platform in October; receipts note determination pending, deductibility retroactive

02 --- Private Funding (Primary Track)

Tier 1 --- Regional Anchors (2026 entry)

Funder Mechanics (verified)	Fit & Strategy
Roundhouse Foundation Jan-Nov 30, 8-12 wk decisions. Open Call: spring (Jan-Mar) and fall (Jun-Aug) cycles. Grants commonly \$10K-\$100K; multi-year possible. Funds 501(c)(3)s, fiscally-sponsored projects, Tribal governments.	Best fit in the country for this project: rural Central Oregon focus, arts/community/education lenses, comfort with grassroots innovation. Sequence: Small Grant LOI in July (launch capacity, ~\$12.5K) → Fall Open Call application in August (flagship two-year program, ~\$48K). One relationship, two asks, properly spaced.

Oregon Community Foundation (Roseburg)	Community Grants: two cycles/yr; Fall 2026 closes June 23; Spring 2027 apps Dec-mid-Jan, decisions ~ May. Up to \$40K, one year. Fiscal sponsorship accepted. Two-cycle sit-out after a win. Rolling applications, no deadlines. Good Neighbor grants (flexible community initiatives) and Technical Assistance grants (orgs under \$1M; consultants, training). Awards commonly \$5K-\$25K+.	Statewide credibility anchor; Central Oregon regional staff in Bend — build the relationship now. Spring 2027 is the planned entry (small-rural priority cycle); June 23 only if sponsorship closes immediately. Also: OCF's donor-advised funds discover grantees through program staff — the relationship compounds. Eligibility nuance, honestly: their “rural” means ≤35K population and not adjacent to a 50K+ metro — Redmond alone is borderline on both. The credible frames: (a) Central Oregon's clearly-rural towns (Sisters, La Pine, Madras, Prineville, Terrebonne, Culver) as the platform's service horizon; (b) a TA grant for organizational capacity benefiting that rural footprint. Call the program officer before applying — they invite it, and the call settles eligibility in ten minutes.
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Tier 2 --- Statewide Foundations (2027, with determination letter)

- **The Collins Foundation** — Oregon-wide; \$5K-\$100K; project and operating support; accessible process. Strong community-welfare fit. Apply after determination, with launch results in hand.
- **Meyer Memorial Trust** — large Oregon funder organized around equity and community power; annual funding opportunities. Moderate fit via community-voice and belonging framing — watch the 2027 opportunity announcements and apply only if the portfolio language genuinely matches.
- **Small Oregon trusts (Autzen Foundation, Rose E. Tucker Charitable Trust, and peers)** — modest general-purpose grants, typically low five figures or less, light applications. Good 2027 fill-ins once determined; verify current guidelines at application time.

Tier 3 — National Civic-Information Funders (watch list + one partnership play)

National civic-tech and local-news philanthropy is real money but episodic, and Steppe is not a newsroom — so this tier is played through positioning and partnership, not cold applications:

- **Press Forward (pooled fund + ~31 local chapters)** — periodic open calls — past rounds funded small local outlets (~\$100K unrestricted) and news infrastructure (\$500K-\$1.5M). The live opportunity is a joint concept with Redmond Compass: Compass as the original-reporting outlet, Steppe as the verified civic-distribution layer — “community information system” is exactly the language their rural cohorts use. Action now: create the Just-Fund organizational profile (coalition funders browse it between open calls) and watch announcements.
- **Adjacent funders (Siegel Family Endowment, Democracy Fund, Knight, and the New Public ecosystem)** — mostly invitation-only or city-bound; treat as relationship and visibility targets — the open-sourced governance model and the transparency reports are the credibility artifacts that get noticed — not as pipeline.

Tier 4 --- Hyper-Local & Corporate (small, fast, trust-building)

Small checks that arrive quickly and — more importantly — put recognizable local names behind the founding story. In a region wary of outside money, a local co-op's logo is worth more than its

dollar amount:

- **Central Electric Cooperative (HQ Redmond)** — member-owned co-op and an active charitable grantmaker (roughly \$950K in recent annual giving). The philosophical kinship is real — a cooperative funding commons infrastructure. Approach by direct inquiry with the one-page case; verify their current program mechanics when you call.
- **First Interstate Bank foundation giving (Redmond branch footprint)** — ongoing local-community grants; small, fast, brand-credible. Verify the current cycle.
- **Mid Oregon Credit Union, BendBroadband/TDS community giving, local Rotary and Kiwanis** — \$500-\$5K sponsorships, especially for events, the internship showcase, and Spanish-language outreach.
- **City of Redmond / Visit Redmond / REDI / Deschutes County discretionary programs** — more civic legitimacy than money; pursue selectively in 2027 under the government-transparency posture.

03 --- Government Funding (Separate Track, 2028+)

POSTURE Government money is accepted — sequenced after local trust is established, used for infrastructure-scale work only, never core operations, and wrapped in radical transparency: every dollar, condition, and reporting obligation published. Refused outright if any condition touches the foundational commitments.

The Honest Federal Landscape (verified June 2026)

- **Digital Equity Act programs — terminated** — all three programs (\$2.75B) were cancelled by the administration in May 2025. Do not plan around them; if reinstated by litigation or a future Congress, the Competitive program would be a strong fit — watch only.
- **USDA Community Connect (FY2026 open) and Distance Learning & Telemedicine** — funded (~\$44M combined) but deployment- and telehealth-shaped — not a platform fit today. Relevant later as a Warm Springs infrastructure pathway.
- **Tribal broadband (NTIA TBCP)** — no open window in 2026; awarded tribes are in build-out. The 2029+ Warm Springs co-application runs through BEAD tribal set-asides and the Oregon Broadband Office instead — begin that relationship in 2027-28.
- **USDA ReConnect** — facing proposed cuts; monitor, don't plan on it.

State & Local (small, mission-specific, 2027--28)

- **Oregon Heritage Commission grants** — the natural funder for the historical-archive feature (Phase 2) — apply only after Warm Springs consultation shapes the archive's design
- **Oregon Humanities** — periodic program grants for community conversation and public dialogue — fits the listening-session and civic-dialogue work
- **Deschutes Cultural Coalition (Oregon Cultural Trust pass-through)** — small annual grants (\$1-3K) for culture and heritage projects — easy, local, archive- and event-adjacent
- **Oregon Broadband Office** — the standing relationship for the Connect program and the Warm Springs horizon — open it in 2027; state broadband deployment subgrants and tribal set-asides both route through this office

The Connect Infrastructure Track (2028+, deployment-shaped)

Steppe Connect — rural connectivity pilots and the Tribal Digital Sovereignty Program — opens a distinct government lane. Every entry follows the posture: infrastructure only, never operations, fully disclosed, and for tribal work the Tribes lead and own everything.

- **USDA Community Connect & Distance Learning/Telemedicine (FY2026 open, ~\$44M combined)** — deployment- and facility-shaped — viable only with a deployment partner (a rural utility cooperative or ISP builds; Steppe is community anchor). The cooperative kinship with Central Electric is the natural opening conversation
- **The coalition path (join first)** — the Oregon Broadband Equity Coalition — OSU Extension-led, free to join, with Tribal Nations, providers, and government at the table — is where rural and tribal connectivity work is coordinated and funded. Link Oregon (network services to tribal/education/nonprofit sectors) and Central Electric Cooperative (Redmond deployment partner) are the technical allies met through it. This network, not a cold application, is the credible entry to every line below
- **State broadband set-asides (via Oregon Broadband Office)** — the live channel for tribal-lands connectivity in 2026+ — the Warm Springs co-application pathway, with the Tribes as lead applicant and owner of all assets. The Warm Springs Community Action Team, a tribal-member-led nonprofit with grant capacity on staff, is the relationship through which this work eventually becomes real — on the Tribes' timeline
- **Federal tribal broadband (NTIA)** — no open window in 2026; awarded tribes are in build-out. Watch for reopening; if it returns, it is the flagship tribal-program vehicle
- **College-led federal education awards (NSF scholarship, technician-education, and two-year-college programs)** — COCC and OSU-Cascades are developing a regional data-literacy and makerspace pathway funded through these institutional channels. Steppe is not the applicant — the honest role is named community partner: deployment sites, internship placements, letters of collaboration, and possibly a modest community-partner subaward. Value to High Desert: pipeline, equipment access, and credibility, not direct revenue
- **Future Ready Oregon / state workforce funds (HECC)** — earn-and-learn money for the internship program's expansion, in partnership with COCC's apprenticeship infrastructure and East Cascades Works (the regional workforce board) — moderate fit, pursue with the college or workforce board as lead. EDCO is the bridge to Business Oregon and the Oregon Innovation Council for any economic-development framing
- **Meta Prineville Community Action Grants (~\$1.4K-\$30K observed; deadline ~November)** — real money with a hard geographic rule: Crook County 501(c)(3)s and schools. Not available to Steppe today; becomes live when Prineville enters petition range or via a Crook County partner organization — flagged for the 2027-28 calendar, honestly conditional

04 --- Resiliency Rules

- Dues fund core operations, always — if every grant vanished tomorrow, the platform runs
- No single funder exceeds 30% of annual revenue; government in total stays ≤25%
- Individual giving is cultivated as the third leg — target ≥15% of revenue by 2028; a hundred locals at \$50 beats one foundation at \$5,000 for both resilience and legitimacy

- Pipeline discipline — once eligible, keep at least three applications live at all times; never depend on any one decision
- No grant whose conditions touch the foundational commitments; every grant and its conditions published in the quarterly transparency report
- Renewal calendar — every award enters a calendar with its report dates and reapplication window the day it arrives
- Partner-as-route — for the ambitious work (connectivity, the bridge program, tribal infrastructure), pursue funding as a subawardee, co-applicant, or deployment partner through an established organization; shared funding is faster, more eligible, and more credible than leading alone, and the founding team states this openness plainly

Revenue Mix Targets

Year	Dues + Individual	Foundations	Government
2026	~60-70%	~30-40% (Roundhouse + locals)	0%
2027	~45-55%	~45-55% (OCF, Collins, Ford)	0%
2028	~40%+	≤40%	≤25%, infrastructure only

05 --- The 18-Month Funding Calendar

When	Actions
June 2026	Fiscal sponsor signed (local first, national fallback). Oregon DOJ registration. MyOCF account by June 18; OCF June 23 only if sponsorship closes in time. Roundhouse intro visit. Decide and document the sponsor's admin fee in all budgets.
July 2026	Roundhouse Small Grants LOI submitted (launch capacity, ~\$12.5K). Ford Family program-officer call — settle the rural-eligibility frame; if green-lit, submit TA inquiry. Founding Supporters campaign built.
August 2026	Roundhouse Fall Open Call application submitted (flagship two-year program, ~\$48K). Press Forward JustFund profile created.
September 2026	Form 1023 filed. CEC and First Interstate inquiries with the one-page case (\$2-8K combined asks).
October 2026	Public launch + Founding Supporters campaign live (goal \$5-10K individual, receipts noting retroactive deductibility). Roundhouse Small Grant decision expected window opens.
November 2026	Roundhouse Open Call decision window. Year-end giving push. OCF Spring 2027 application drafted
December 2026	Enter the Master Case (window opens ~Dec 1, closes mid-January).
Q1 2027	OCF Spring application submitted by mid-January. Determination letter expected window begins — on arrival: Collins application out within 30 days; sponsor wind-down per agreement.
Q2-2027	OCF decision (~May). Collins decision. Meyer opportunity evaluated against actual 2027 guidelines.
Q3 2027	Deschutes Cultural Coalition small grant (archive/heritage framing) if cycle aligns. First grant reports filed on time — the renewal calendar is now live.
Q4 2027	Renewals (Roundhouse year two, OCF after sit-out). Oregon Broadband Office relationship opened. College/makerspace MOUs signed; community-partner role in college-led federal proposals formalized.
- 2028	First Connect rural-access pilot grant assembled (USDA or state, with a cooperative deployment partner). Meta Prineville window evaluated if Crook County routing exists. Press Forward open calls watched; Compass joint concept ready if one fits.

Realistic Raise Projections

- 2026: \$15K-\$40K — Roundhouse small grant and/or Open Call, hyper-local checks, Founding Supporters
- 2027: \$40K-\$90K — OCF + Collins + Ford TA + renewals + individual growth

- 2028: \$75K-\$150K — diversified per the mix targets, internships and town #2 grant-funded

These are planning numbers, not promises — sized so that the budget ladder in the business plan works at the low end of every range.

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